

The Second Language

She had been teaching English for twenty years. She had not expected her student to change what she thought language was for.

CEFR Level B2

Book 5 of 10 • Literary Drama / Teaching / Identity • Adult Graded Reader Series

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About This Book

Setting: A language school in Bristol. A classroom. The relationship between a teacher and one student.

Genre: Literary Drama / Teaching / Identity

Characters

- Miranda — 52. EFL teacher. Experienced, principled, quietly dissatisfied with the instrumental approach that dominates the school.
- Adama — 34. Her student. A Malian lawyer, currently a refugee awaiting status. Precise, philosophical, resistant to the usual methods.
- The school director — Margaret, 58. Efficient. Commercial. Not hostile, but limited.
- The language itself — what it can and cannot do.

THE SECOND LANGUAGE

Page 1 — The New Intake

Miranda had been teaching English as a foreign language for twenty-two years, and she had, in that time, developed a finely calibrated set of expectations about new students.

She expected, at the start of each term, a range of motivation — some students there because they needed the language for professional advancement, some because it was required for residency, some because they had been told it was important without being told for what.

She expected, in any given cohort of fifteen, two or three who would genuinely engage with the material, seven or eight who would make serviceable progress through honest effort, and the remainder whose attendance was in some sense performative.

Adama Coulibaly did not fit any of these categories.

Vocabulary Support

calibrated	kalibre edilmiş
cohort	grup, kohortu
serviceable progress	yeterli ilerleme
performative attendance	göstermelik devam
residency	ikamet

professional advancement	mesleki ilerleme
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He did not fit any of her categories. After twenty-two years, this was itself notable.

Page 2 — Adama

Adama Coulibaly was thirty-four and had been, before circumstances she did not initially know the details of had brought him to Bristol, a practising lawyer in Bamako.

He had been in the country for fourteen months. His asylum case was pending — he had told her this directly, in their first one-to-one, in the same tone he might have used to report a fact about a third party.

He spoke functional English — sufficient for daily interaction — and the formal written French of his legal training, which was, he had told her, his professional language rather than his mother tongue.

His mother tongue was Bambara.

'So,' Miranda had said, 'you are learning your fourth language.' 'My third functional language,' he had corrected, with the precision of someone who made legal distinctions professionally. 'Bambara is not a language I have learned. It is a language I exist in.'

Vocabulary Support

asylum case	iltica davası
pending	beklemede
mother tongue	ana dil
Bambara	Bambara dili

Bamako	Mali başkenti
functional language	işlevsel dil

"Bambara is not a language I have learned. It is a language I exist in." That distinction changed everything.

Page 3 — The Distinction

Miranda had heard various phrasings of the idea before — the difference between acquired and native language, between the language you think in and the language you perform in — but she had not heard it put quite that way, and it stayed with her.

She found herself returning to it during the first month, initially as a professional observation and increasingly as something more personal.

She had been teaching English — a language she was native in, a language she had never experienced as something external to herself — for twenty-two years.

She had, she realised, been teaching students to acquire something she had never had to acquire.

She had always known this, in the abstract.

Adama had made it concrete.

Vocabulary Support

acquired language	edinilmiş dil
abstract	soyut
concrete	somut
external to	... in dışında
phrasings	ifade biçimleri
stays with her	aklında kalıyor

*She had always known this in the abstract. He made it concrete.
That is what good students do.*

Page 4 — The Instrumental Problem

The school where Miranda taught — a private language school with a reasonable reputation and an unambiguously commercial orientation — had, in the previous three years, moved increasingly towards what the director called outcomes-based teaching.

Miranda had no objection, in principle, to outcomes. Outcomes were what students needed. The problem, as she had articulated it to colleagues who were prepared to listen, was not the outcomes themselves but the implicit theory of language that the outcomes-based approach embodied.

The theory held that language was, fundamentally, a tool — a means of transacting information and desires, the quality of which could be assessed by the efficiency of the transaction.

This theory was, she thought, mostly adequate and substantially wrong.

Vocabulary Support

outcomes-based	sonuç odaklı
unambiguously	açık biçimde
commercial orientation	ticari yönelim
embody	somutlaştırmak
transacting	işlem yapmak
fundamentally	temelde

Mostly adequate and substantially wrong. That is her view of the dominant theory of language.

Page 5 — Adama and the Theory

Adama had identified the same problem from a different angle.

In their third one-to-one, he had said: 'The exercises you give me are designed to make me useful in English. They are not designed to make me present in English.'

Miranda had written this down afterwards, which was not something she normally did with things students said.

'Is there a difference?' she had asked, though she had known the answer.

'Yes. A useful language transaction transfers information. A present language transaction transfers a person. At the moment, I can transfer information in English. I cannot transfer myself.'

Miranda had looked at him.

'That,' she said, 'is what the curriculum does not address.'

'I know,' he said. 'That is why I am telling you.'

Vocabulary Support

designed to	... için tasarlanmış
transfer a person	bir kişiyi aktarmak

curriculum	müfredat
address	ele almak
present in	... de mevcut olmak
transaction	işlem

*"I cannot transfer myself." He named the gap in the curriculum.
And he told her because she could do something about it.*

Page 6 — What She Did

What Miranda did, in response to this conversation, was not formally significant — she did not redesign the curriculum or challenge the director's outcomes model.

What she did was alter, within the margins available to her, the texture of Adama's instruction.

She gave him texts that were not chosen for their vocabulary range but for their engagement with the kind of thinking he was already doing — Achebe, Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, James Baldwin, Toni Morrison.

She gave him writing tasks that were not language exercises but invitations to think on the page.

She was aware that she was, in some sense, teaching him a version of the subject that the school was not specifically paying her to teach.

She was also aware that it was the correct version.

Vocabulary Support

texture	doku
margins available	mevcut alan
invitations to think	düşünmeye davet
engagement with	... ile meşguliyet
not specifically paying	özellikle ödemiıyor

alter	değiřtirmek
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Teaching a version the school was not paying her to teach. She was aware of this. She did it anyway.

Page 7 — The Writing

The writing tasks produced something Miranda had not anticipated.

Adama's written English was, at the start of the term, precise and correct and, in a way she found difficult to diagnose at first, slightly absent.

It was the English of someone who had mastered the grammar and vocabulary of the language and was deploying it with the competence of a professional translator: accurate, but without the particular weight that came from the writer's own investment.

By the sixth week, something had changed.

She could not have specified the mechanism of the change. But the sentences had acquired a quality — a specificity, a willingness to occupy the language rather than merely use it — that had not been there before.

Vocabulary Support

absent	eksik, yok
deploying	kullanmak, yerleştirmek
investment	yatırım, kişisel bağ
specificity	özgüllük
occupy the language	dili işgal etmek
mechanism	mekanizma

Occupy the language rather than merely use it. The change she could not specify but could feel.

Page 8 — The Essay

In the seventh week, he submitted an essay she had asked him to write on the topic of home.

The topic was deliberately vague — she had learned, over many years, that vague topics produced more revealing writing than specific ones.

The essay was, by any measure she had applied to student writing over twenty-two years, exceptional.

It was not exceptional because of its grammar, which was accurate, or its vocabulary, which was sophisticated but not showy. It was exceptional because it did what good writing did: it placed the reader in a position they could not have reached without the text.

She read it twice. Then she read it again the next morning.

She thought: I have not read anything this good in a long time.

She thought: he has arrived in the language.

Vocabulary Support

deliberately vague	kasıtlı olarak belirsiz
revealing	açığa çıkarıcı
sophisticated	sofistike
showy	gösterişli

placed the reader	okuyucuyu bir yere koydu
arrived in the language	dile ulařtı

*"He has arrived in the language." Twenty-two years of teaching.
She knows what this looks like.*

Page 9 — What the Essay Said

The essay said, among other things:

Home is a language problem before it is a geographical one. When I left Mali, I understood that I had lost a place. I have spent fourteen months learning that I also lost a language — not Bambara, which I cannot lose because I did not acquire it, but the way the world presented itself to me in Bambara. The problem is not that English does not have words for the things Bambara describes. The problem is that the things English notices are not the same things Bambara notices. To become present in English, I have to learn not only a new language but a new attention.

Miranda read this paragraph several times.

She thought: this is one of the most accurate descriptions of the experience of language acquisition I have read, and it was written by a student who has been in the country for fourteen months.

Vocabulary Support

geographical	coğrafi
attention	dikkat, farketme
presents itself	kendini sunar
accurate description	doğru açıklama
language acquisition	dil edinimi

notices	fark eder
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"Not a new language but a new attention." He has named what language learning actually is.

Page 10 — Miranda and Margaret

Miranda had taken the essay to Margaret, the director, with a specific purpose.

She wanted, she told herself, Margaret to understand what was being achieved in the classroom.

What she actually wanted — and what she acknowledged, with the honesty she applied to her own motivations, when she had had time to think about it — was for Margaret to see something that the outcomes model could not produce and could not measure.

Margaret had read the essay. She had said: 'This is impressive. What level is he?'

Miranda had looked at her.

'B2 moving towards C1,' she had said.

'Good progress,' Margaret said.

Miranda had thought: she has not understood what she read. And then: I knew she would not. This was about something else.

Vocabulary Support

specific purpose	belirli amaç
outcomes model	sonuç modeli
motivations	güdüler

impressed	etkilenmiş
acknowledged	kabul etti
something else	başka bir şey

*"Good progress." Margaret measured it. She did not read it.
Miranda knew she would not.*

Page 11 — Adama's Case

Adama's asylum case was decided in November.

He was granted leave to remain.

He told Miranda at the end of the lesson in which the result came through — he had received the letter that morning but had not mentioned it until the end of the class, which she thought was one of the most precise pieces of self-knowledge she had observed in a student.

He had known, she thought, that if he mentioned it at the beginning, the lesson would have become about the case rather than about the work.

'Congratulations,' she said. 'What will you do?'

'I will qualify my legal training for the UK system,' he said. 'I am told it takes two years. I will need the English to do it properly.'

'You have the English,' she said.

'I have enough English,' he said. 'I want the English.'

Vocabulary Support

leave to remain	kalma izni
qualify	yeniden onaylatmak
asylum case	iltica davası

precisely	tam olarak
self-knowledge	öz farkındalık
properly	düzgünce

"I have enough English. I want the English." He is describing the difference she has been teaching towards.

Page 12 — What He Wanted

She had understood, from that exchange, something that would have been, before the term, too fine a distinction to draw.

He was not saying he wanted more English — more vocabulary, more grammatical range, more fluency.

He was saying he wanted the English in the same way he had Bambara — not as a language he used, but as a language he existed in.

He knew this might not be fully achievable. Second languages, in her experience, were rarely fully inhabited in the way that first languages were.

But he wanted to go as far as it was possible to go.

And he knew — she could tell from the way he had said it — that this was a different thing from the language the school had been teaching him.

It was the language she had been trying to teach him.

Vocabulary Support

fine a distinction	narin bir ayrım
fluency	akıcılık
inhabited	içinde yaşanan
achievable	ulaşılabilir
fully inhabited	tamamen sahip olunan

rarely	nadiren
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The language the school taught vs the language she was trying to teach. He could tell the difference.

Page 13 — The Question He Asked

In the penultimate lesson, Adama asked her a question she had not been asked in twenty-two years.

He said: 'Can I ask — why do you teach this? Not why you teach English, but why you teach it the way you do, which is different from the others.'

Miranda had thought about this properly before answering.

She had said: 'Because I think language is more than a tool, and I think people who learn it as nothing more than a tool are being given something less than what's available. I teach it the way I do because I want students to have access to the whole thing.'

'What is the whole thing?' he had asked.

She had thought again.

'The capacity to be present in it,' she had said. 'Which is what you have been working towards.'

'Yes,' he said. 'Thank you for knowing that was where I was going.'

Vocabulary Support

penultimate	sondan bir önceki
properly	düzgünce
more than a tool	araçtan fazlası

access to	... e erişim
working towards	... e doğru çalışmak
capacity	kapasite

"Thank you for knowing that was where I was going." She had seen it. He knew she had seen it.

Page 14 — The Last Lesson

The last lesson of the term was, by the school's conventions, a review session — a recap of grammar structures, a vocabulary test, preparation for the end-of-term assessment.

Miranda had completed the review.

She had then, in the remaining twenty minutes, departed from the convention.

She had asked each student to write one sentence — only one — about what they wanted to say in English that they could not yet say.

The sentences ranged from the practical to the unexpectedly large.

Adama's sentence was: 'I want to be understood, in English, in the way that I understand myself.'

She had read it twice.

She thought: that is a life's work.

She thought: you have already begun.

Vocabulary Support

convention	gelenek, alışkanlık
recap	gözden geçirme
departed from	... den ayrılmak
unexpectedly large	beklenmedik biçimde büyük

life's work	ömür boyu sürececek iş
understood	anlaşılmaq

"You have already begun." A life's work. And he has already begun. She knows this.

Page 15 — What Changed

Miranda had, since the term ended, been trying to identify what Adama's presence in her classroom had changed.

She had not changed her practice dramatically — she was still teaching within the school's framework, still addressing the outcomes the director required.

But something had shifted in the way she held the work.

She had, for some years, been teaching with a sense of mild, accumulated disappointment — not at the students, but at the gap between what she knew language could do and what the institutional constraints permitted her to teach.

The disappointment was still there. But it was accompanied, now, by something she had not had for some time: a sense of what was possible.

Vocabulary Support

dramatically	dramatik biçimde
framework	çerçeve
institutional constraints	kurumsal kısıtlamalar
accumulated disappointment	birikmiş hayal kırıklığı
accompanied by	... ile birlikte

sense of what was
possible

mümkün olanın hissi

The disappointment was still there. But now accompanied by a sense of what was possible.

Page 16 — The Second Language

She had been thinking about what a second language did to the person learning it.

Not the standard answer — it expanded communicative range, it opened professional and social doors, it provided cognitive benefits — all of which were true.

She was thinking about the other thing: what it demanded.

Learning a language as an adult required you to become, in some respects, less competent in the world than you had been before. It required you to accept a period — in some cases, an extended period — of diminished expressiveness, of reaching for words that were not there, of knowing what you meant and being unable to say it.

Very few things, in adult life, required this.

She thought: the willingness to undertake this is not merely a linguistic skill. It is a kind of courage.

Vocabulary Support

communicative range	iletişimsel kapsam
cognitive benefits	bilişsel faydalar
diminished expressiveness	azalmış ifade gücü

extended period	uzun dönem
willingness	isteklilik
courage	cesaret

"A kind of courage." Not a linguistic skill. She had been teaching courage without naming it.

Page 17 — Miranda and Language

She had, in the months after the term, found herself thinking about Bambara.

She had looked it up — its phonological structure, its tonal system, the ways in which its organisation of meaning differed from the Indo-European languages she was familiar with.

She could not learn it from an article, and she had not tried.

But the research had done something she had not expected: it had made visible, to her, the architecture of English in a way that habitual native fluency typically obscured.

You saw your own language most clearly, she thought, when you stood beside someone who did not share it.

She had been teaching English for twenty-two years.

She had, for the first time in several years, seen it.

Vocabulary Support

phonological structure	ses bilgisi yapısı
tonal system	tonal sistem
obscured	gizlemişti
habitual native fluency	alışkanlıkla edinilmiş ana dil akıcılığı

architecture of language	dilin mimarisi
stood beside	yanında durmak

She saw English most clearly when she stood beside someone who did not share it.

She had, at the end-of-year meeting with Margaret, made an attempt at the argument she had been developing.

She had said: 'The outcomes model measures what can be measured, which is a subset of what language learning produces. The students who progress most significantly in my experience are not the ones who optimise for the measurable outcomes. They are the ones who are willing to become present in the language, which is a different undertaking entirely.'

Margaret had listened. She had said: 'I understand the distinction you're drawing. The question is what we do with it institutionally.'

'I know,' Miranda had said. 'I'm not proposing a curriculum change. I'm proposing that we acknowledge, even internally, that the outcomes are not the whole picture.'

'I can do that,' Margaret said. 'I'm not sure it changes anything.'

'Acknowledgement sometimes precedes change,' Miranda said.

Vocabulary Support

optimise for

... için optimize etmek

undertaking	girişim
subset	alt küme
institutionally	kurumsal olarak
precedes	önce gelir
acknowledgement	kabul

"Acknowledgement sometimes precedes change." She planted a seed. She does not know if it will grow.

Page 19 — Adama, Later

She heard from Adama twice in the year after the course.

The first time was a brief email saying that he had enrolled in a conversion programme for internationally-qualified lawyers and was finding it, he said, 'both easier and harder than expected — easier because the legal reasoning translates, harder because the English the law uses is a different English from the English I have.'

She had written back: 'Yes. Legal English is a dialect of the language with its own grammar of precision and its own habits of euphemism. You will learn it. It will not be the whole language.'

The second time was eleven months later. He had passed the first year of the conversion. He was, he said, 'becoming more present in the law, which I think is what you meant about the language.'

She thought: yes. That is exactly what I meant.

Vocabulary Support

conversion programme	dönüşüm programı
translates	aktarılır
dialect	lehçe
euphemism	örtmece

habits of precision	kesinlik alışkanlıkları
becoming more present	daha fazla mevcut olmak

"Becoming more present in the law." He applied her teaching beyond the language. That is what good teaching does.

Page 20 — What Language Is For

She had been asked, at a professional development session, to contribute a single sentence about what language teaching was for.

She had written: Language teaching, at its best, is not the instruction of a communicative tool but the facilitation of presence — the provision of the means by which a person can become, in a second language, as fully themselves as they are in their first.

The session leader had read it aloud. There had been a short silence.

Someone had said: 'Is that achievable?'

'Rarely in full,' Miranda had said. 'But it is the right thing to aim for. The aim shapes the practice, even when the aim isn't fully reached.'

She had thought about Adama, who had been, in English, more fully himself than most native speakers she had met.

She had thought: I have been aiming for this for twenty-two years. I have occasionally hit it.

That, she thought, was enough.

Vocabulary Support

facilitation	kolaylaştırma
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provision	sağlama
fully themselves	tamamen kendileri
shapes the practice	uygulamayı şekillendirir
professional development	mesleki gelişim
achievable	ulaşılabilir

"I have occasionally hit it. That is enough." Twenty-two years. One right aim. Occasionally hit. Enough.

ACTIVITIES

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase	Meaning
1. calibrated	A. edinilmiş dil
2. acquired language	B. kalibre edilmiş
3. instrumental	C. araçsal
4. facilitation	D. kolaylaştırma
5. euphemism	E. örtmece
6. dialect	F. lehçe
7. diminished expressiveness	G. azalmış ifade gücü
8. undertaking	H. girişim

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

present — Bambara — attention — courage — aim — tool

1. Adama said _____ was not a language he learned but a language he existed in.
2. He distinguished between being useful in English and being _____ in English.
3. His essay said that to become present in English, he had to learn not only a new language but a new _____.

4. Miranda concluded that willingness to undertake language learning was not merely a linguistic skill but a kind of _____.
5. The outcomes model treated language fundamentally as a _____ — a means of transacting information.
6. Miranda said the _____ shapes the practice, even when the aim is not fully reached.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Adama is a student who is motivated by professional advancement. ____
2. The school's approach is described as outcomes-based teaching. ____
3. Adama's asylum case is rejected. ____
4. Margaret is deeply impressed by Adama's essay. ____
5. Miranda changes the school's curriculum after the term.

6. Adama passes the first year of his legal conversion programme. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What distinction does Adama draw between a 'useful' and a 'present' language transaction?
8. What does Miranda change about Adama's instruction, and why does she feel ambivalent about it?
9. What does Adama's essay say about home as a language problem?
10. What does Miranda mean when she says Adama's writing went from 'absent' to 'occupying the language'?
11. Why does Miranda take the essay to Margaret, and what happens?
12. What does Adama say he wants that is different from having 'enough English'?

13. What does Miranda say language learning demands that few other adult experiences do?

14. How does Miranda's research into Bambara change her perception of English?

15. What does Miranda say at the end about the aim of language teaching, and why does she think it is enough to occasionally hit it?

ANSWER KEY

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. Bambara 2. present 3. attention 4. courage 5. tool 6. aim

True / False: 1. F 2. T 3. F 4. F 5. F 6. T

7. A useful transaction transfers information accurately. A present transaction transfers a person — the full weight of who they are. Adama can do the first but not yet the second.

8. She assigns literary texts and thinking-on-the-page writing tasks rather than language exercises. She feels ambivalent because she is teaching something the school is not paying her to teach — but she knows it is the correct version.

9. Home is a language problem before a geographical one. Losing Mali meant losing not just a place but the way the world presented itself in Bambara — the things Bambara notices. English notices different things, requiring a new attention.

10. The early writing was grammatically correct but deployed without personal investment — like a professional translator. By week six, it had acquired specificity and a willingness to occupy rather than merely use the language.

11. She wants Margaret to see what the outcomes model cannot produce or measure. Margaret reads the essay and calls it 'good progress' — she has measured it but not read it. Miranda knew this would happen.

12. He wants English in the same way he has Bambara — not a language he uses but one he exists in.

13. It requires accepting diminished expressiveness — becoming less competent than you were before, reaching for words that are not there, knowing what you mean but being unable to say it. This is a kind of courage.

14. It made visible the architecture of English — habitual native fluency typically obscures the structure of one's own language. You see it most clearly when standing beside someone who does not share it.

15. Language teaching at its best facilitates presence — providing means for a person to become as fully themselves in a second language as in their first. It is rarely achieved in full, but the aim shapes the practice. She has occasionally hit it in twenty-two years. That is enough.